

## **Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)**

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# Obadiah

## Obadiah

Cain, one of the sons of Adam, asked, “Am I my brother’s keeper?” This question has become a picture of refusing responsibility. But Cain had murdered his brother Abel. A person also shares guilt by doing nothing when innocent people suffer.

Edom was both Judah’s neighbor and relative. Yet Edom watched with delight and joined in when Babylon destroyed Jerusalem. So God held Edom responsible for this evil. God’s judgment always follows this kind of injustice.

## Setting

The people of Edom came from Esau, the brother of Jacob (see Genesis 25:30). The Edomites lived mainly in the highlands (hill country) east of the Arabah (the Jordan Valley south of the Dead Sea) and south of the Dead Sea.

Edom existed during most of the time of Israel’s kings (about 1050–586 BC). At times, Edom was under the control of the southern kingdom of Judah (this is called a vassal, meaning a smaller kingdom ruled by a stronger one; 2 Samuel 8:14; 1 Kings 11:14–16; 2 Kings 8:20–22; compare 2 Kings 3:9–14).

Around 600–400 BC, Arab kingdoms likely moved into Edom and took control of the land. After the exile and into New Testament times, Edom appeared again in southern Judah. It was then called Idumea (the Greek name for Edom). One well-known person from this region was Herod the Great, who called himself the “King of the Jews.”

As a nation, Edom repeated Esau’s earlier hatred toward Jacob. For example, Edom refused to help Israel during the exodus from Egypt and blocked their way (Numbers 20:14–21; 21:4).

Much later, the Babylonians attacked Judah and took the people into exile (forced removal from their land). At that time, Edom did not help Judah. Instead, they rejoiced and supported Babylon. They also tried to gain wealth from Judah’s fall.

This unfaithfulness toward their “brother” Israel led to the message of the prophet Obadiah.

## Summary

The book of Obadiah has two main themes: the destruction of Edom and the restoration (bringing back and healing) of Judah.

In the introduction (1:1–9), a messenger calls the nations to attack Edom. God announces judgment against Edom. This judgment will destroy Edom’s pride. The people trusted in their strong mountain location and in their wisdom, but these would not save them.

In the second section (1:10–14), Obadiah explains why Edom will be punished. He lists their wrong actions in a series of sharp statements (taunts, meaning words that expose and shame wrongdoing). Edom had a duty to help their “brother” Jacob (Israel). Instead, they turned against them and refused to help.

In the third and final section (1:15–21), Obadiah describes the coming “Day of the LORD” (a time when God judges evil and sets things right). Those who do evil will face serious consequences (1:15–16). Those who have suffered unfairly will be restored (1:17–21).

The people of Jerusalem will return and take back their land. Their territory will grow in every direction. Edom will be brought under their rule as an example of what happens to those who oppose the Lord. In the end, the whole world will recognize the Lord as King.

## Author and Date

Obadiah’s name means “servant of the Lord.” We know about him only from this book and from clues in the text about his time and place. Several people in the Old Testament were named Obadiah. One example is a palace official who served King Ahab (1 Kings 18:3–16).

Obadiah gave his message after the kingdom of Judah was invaded. In 586 BC, the Babylonian king Nebuchadnezzar ended Judah’s independence. He destroyed Jerusalem and took the last king, Zedekiah, into exile (2 Kings 25:1–30).

Outside the book of Obadiah, the Bible says little about how Edom responded to this event (see also Isaiah 34:5–10). Obadiah likely wrote his prophecy soon after Babylon destroyed Jerusalem in 586 BC.

## Literary Features

Obadiah’s message about Edom is similar to the messages of other prophets. Parts of his prophecy closely match Jeremiah 49:9, 14–16. For this reason, it is helpful to study Obadiah alongside other prophecies about Edom’s future. His message may also expand on shorter passages such as Joel 3:19 and Amos 9:12.

## Meaning and Message

At first, Obadiah’s prophecy may seem like a harsh message about the Lord’s anger against Israel’s ene-

mies. The Lord's anger is real, and evil will not go unpunished. But this short book has a deeper message than this simple view.

Nations, like individuals, should think carefully about what they do, because the results will come soon. God is offended by wrongdoing, and he brings justice for people who are harmed or treated unfairly (the oppressed).

What Edom did to Judah, whether by action or by doing nothing, would come back on them. This follows an ancient law of justice called *lex talionis* (a Latin phrase meaning "the law of equal response"). It means that a person receives the same kind of action they have done: "As you have done, it will be done to you" (1:15).

The day of the Lord will come suddenly. It will bring full justice for those who have suffered, punishment for those who do wrong, and the beginning of a kingdom where the Lord rules over all nations.

In the near (historical) sense, this meant that Israel would return to their land and rule over the land of Edom. But in a wider (universal) sense, Edom's punishment is only part of a larger judgment. Not only Edom, but all nations will face the Lord's judgment (1:16).

When the Lord comes as King and restores Jerusalem, Mount Zion (the hill in Jerusalem where the temple stood) will be at the center of this new order.

This view of God is central to the message of Obadiah. It calls all people today to make a choice. Who will we serve? Will we serve a god who ignores evil, or the God of justice shown in Obadiah? Only a God who judges evil can give us confidence that evil will not win in the end.

Obadiah anticipates a new time when "the kingdom will belong to the LORD" (1:21). This hope first belonged to Israel, but it later became a hope for the whole world. Jesus announced this same hope when he said, "the kingdom of God is near" (Mark 1:15; Luke 10:9-12; 21:31-33).